

33 Wishes and regrets

English uses the verb “wish” to talk about present and past regrets. The tense of the verb that follows “wish” affects the meaning of the sentence.

See also:

Past simple 7 Past perfect simple 13

Modal verbs 56

33.1 “WISH” AND PAST SIMPLE

“Wish” is used with the past simple to express regrets and desires about the present, which could still happen or come true.

I **wish** I **earned** more money.

The past simple is used here to talk about the present.



FURTHER EXAMPLES

Mike’s apartment is too small. He **wishes** he **lived** in a bigger house.



They **wish** the weather **was** better so they could go to the beach.



You’re always busy, I **wish** you **didn’t have to** work so hard.



Sandra hates her job. She **wishes** she **worked** on a farm.



HOW TO FORM

SUBJECT

“WISH”

SUBJECT

PAST SIMPLE

REST OF SENTENCE

I

wish

I

earned

more money.

“Wish” or “wishes,” depending on the subject.

The past simple expresses wishes or regrets about the present.